🏀 A Data-Driven Analysis of Scoring, Playmaking, and Team Design (2021–2022 NBA Season)

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At a surface level, Utah appears to be a high-performing team, ranking among the top in scoring and rebounding, while also demonstrating strong three-point shooting across multiple positions. These metrics suggest a well-balanced and efficient offensive system.

However, performance metrics alone do not fully explain team effectiveness.

This analysis moves beyond traditional statistics to examine the structure behind Utah's offensive production, focusing on scoring, playmaking, and positional contribution.

The objective of this project is to identify where the team performs well, where gaps exist, and what type of player profile could strengthen the overall system.

To achieve this, the analysis follows a structured approach:

> **Analyze → Diagnose → Recommend**

📊 Strong Shooting Across Positions

Across multiple positions, Utah demonstrates strong three-point efficiency, particularly among guards and forwards. This level of shooting typically reflects effective spacing — a key component of modern offensive systems.

In most cases, strong perimeter shooting is associated with higher assist production, as spacing creates more opportunities for ball movement and open shots.

However, this expected relationship does not fully appear in Utah's data.

This suggests that while shooting efficiency is a strength, it is not the limiting factor within the offensive system.

Accurate 3-Point Shooting by Team and Position

AGG(True 3P% by Posi...
0.00% 42.03%

Tm	Current Pos: C	PF	PG	SF	SG
ATL	42.03%	37.06%	37.74%	37.39%	36.92%
BOS	33.55%	40.27%	36.01%	34.92%	35.34%
BRK	26.48%	35.71%	34.91%	40.17%	38.13%
CHI	31.25%	36.02%	39.87%	34.93%	37.81%
CHO	36.16%	32.72%	39.04%	36.41%	37.23%
CLE	38.52%	30.77%	36.59%	35.15%	31.65%
DAL	34.88%	35.18%	35.14%	35.51%	34.52%
DEN	33.43%	33.38%	35.90%	20.00%	37.03%
DET	32.87%	32.91%	31.47%	33.95%	31.78%
GSW	36.00%	35.56%	37.56%	35.54%	36.36%
HOU	34.33%	30.63%	37.57%	33.86%	34.82%
IND	31.90%	34.06%	34.51%	34.55%	35.17%
LAC	41.30%	37.74%	31.29%	37.67%	37.52%
LAL	34.02%	35.86%	31.19%	31.21%	36.18%
MEM	31.03%	29.41%	36.44%	31.09%	40.00%
MIA	30.88%	39.53%	37.53%	37.92%	38.27%
MIL	37.39%	30.84%	37.93%	37.27%	37.40%
MIN	38.91%	33.86%	33.88%	24.53%	36.79%
NOP	35.68%	36.03%	32.57%	31.92%	33.07%
NYK	36.59%	30.77%	35.08%	33.62%	39.22%
OKC	38.34%	31.88%	31.91%	29.48%	31.78%
ORL	35.86%	32.08%	30.39%	33.55%	34.31%
PHI	35.53%	38.82%	39.31%	37.73%	33.19%
PHO	32.56%	37.59%	33.19%	35.33%	37.59%
POR	27.74%	32.51%	30.37%	33.82%	37.15%
SAC	31.12%	36.78%	30.59%	28.86%	36.52%
SAS	32.37%	40.91%	30.77%	36.49%	34.37%
TOR	32.75%	32.97%	35.75%	33.12%	38.28%
UTA	0.00%	37.79%	39.46%	37.29%	33.41%
WAS	27.59%	36.08%	31.26%	33.51%	35.57%

Figure 1: Utah demonstrates strong three-point efficiency across multiple positions, indicating that shooting and spacing are not the primary limitations within the offensive system.

💡 Key Insight

> Utah's shooting profile is strong, indicating that scoring efficiency is not the primary limitation.

High Scoring, Low Playmaking: An Offensive Outlier

When comparing team scoring and assist production across the league, a consistent pattern emerges: teams that score at a high level also tend to generate high assist totals. This reflects offensive systems built on ball movement, spacing, and shared creation.

However, the Utah Jazz do not follow this pattern.

While Utah ranks among the top teams in total scoring, their assist production is significantly lower than other teams within the same scoring range. Utah appears as a clear outlier — producing points without proportional playmaking.

Figure 2: Utah scores at a level comparable to top teams but generates fewer assists, highlighting a gap between scoring output and playmaking.

This gap indicates that Utah's offensive system relies less on distributed creation and more on concentrated scoring mechanisms.

Playmaking Structure at the Player Level

A deeper analysis at the player level reveals how this imbalance is created.

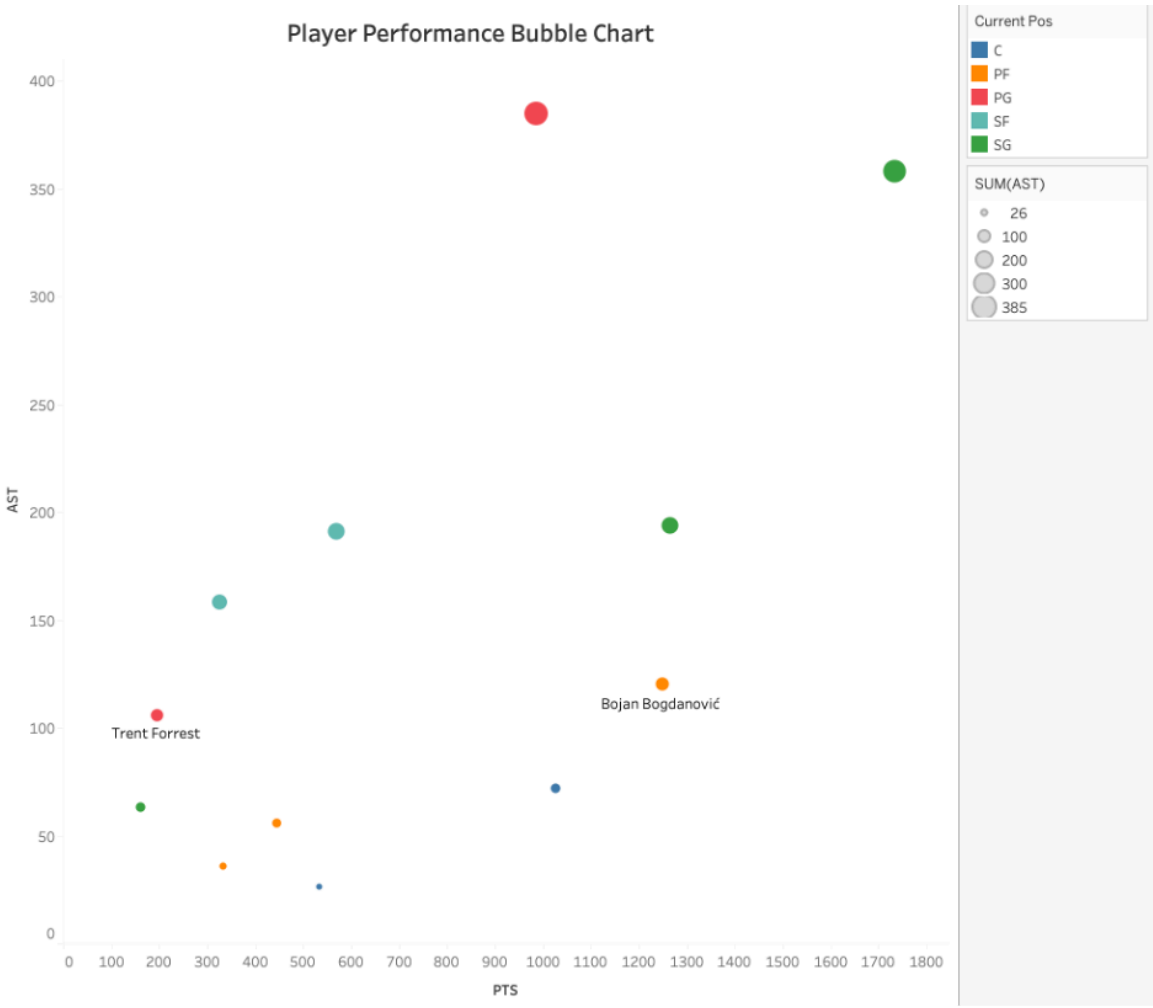

Figure 3: Player-Level Scoring vs. Playmaking Distribution.

This chart illustrates the relationship between scoring (points) and playmaking (assists) among Utah Jazz players.

Playmaking is heavily concentrated among a small number of players, particularly primary ball handlers such as Mike Conley, who leads the team in assist production. While Donovan Mitchell contributes significantly to scoring, his assist production is comparatively lower relative to his scoring volume.

Other players show limited involvement in playmaking, as indicated by smaller bubble sizes, suggesting that secondary creation is minimal across the roster.

This imbalance highlights that offensive responsibilities are not evenly distributed, with most playmaking responsibilities concentrated in a few key players rather than shared across positions.

💡 Key Insight

> Playmaking is concentrated among a small number of players, **revealing a lack of secondary creators** in Utah's offensive system.

Scoring Distribution by Position

Utah's scoring distribution further reinforces this pattern.

Rather than balanced contributions across all positions, scoring is driven primarily by specific roles — particularly shooting guards and power forwards. While this specialization can improve efficiency, it also reduces offensive flexibility.

When scoring responsibilities are concentrated, offensive systems become more predictable and easier to defend, especially against high-level competition.

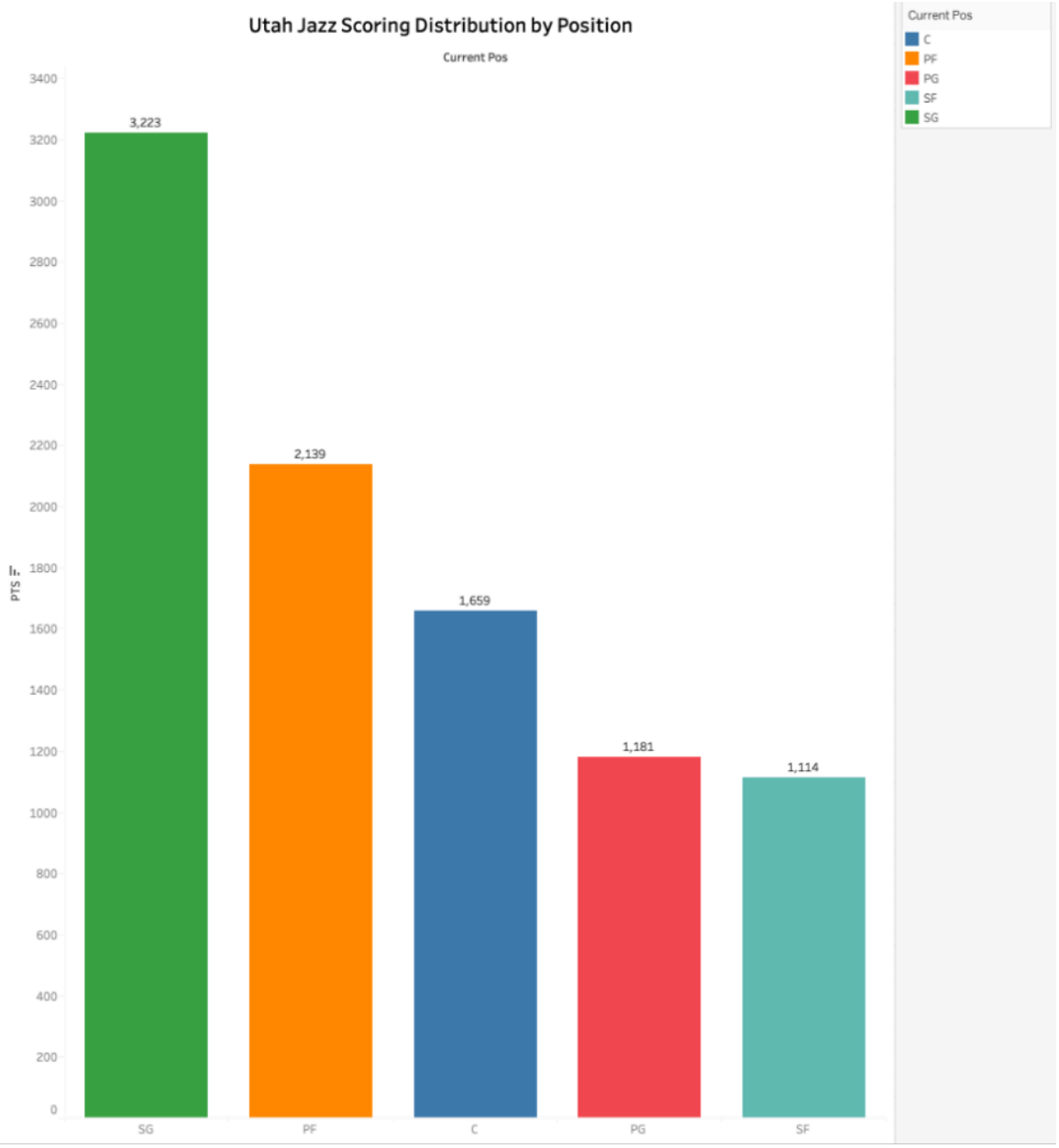

Figure 4: Scoring Distribution by Position

Utah's scoring production is concentrated among specific positions, particularly shooting guards and power forwards. The shooting guard position leads by a significant margin, while other positions contribute at noticeably lower levels.

This distribution indicates a reliance on role-specific scoring rather than balanced offensive contributions across all positions.

💡 Key Insight

> Scoring is concentrated in specific positions, reducing offensive balance and limiting flexibility.

How Elite Teams Differ

When compared to top-performing teams, a different offensive structure becomes evident.

Elite teams tend to distribute playmaking responsibilities across multiple positions, rather than relying on a single primary creator. This creates a more dynamic and unpredictable offensive system, where multiple players can initiate plays and generate scoring opportunities.

In contrast, Utah's offensive structure is more centralized, with playmaking concentrated among a limited number of players. While this approach can be effective in stable conditions, it reduces flexibility and makes the offense more predictable against stronger defensive teams.

Core Diagnosis

This is not a performance issue — it is a structural one.

While the Utah Jazz demonstrate strong scoring efficiency and overall offensive production, their system relies heavily on a limited number of playmakers to generate offense. This creates an imbalance where scoring output is not supported by distributed playmaking.

As a result, the offense becomes more predictable and less adaptable, particularly in high-pressure situations where defensive intensity increases. Without multiple creators on the floor, the team's ability to adjust and generate high-quality opportunities is reduced.

This structural limitation, rather than a lack of talent, is the primary constraint within Utah's offensive system.

Recommendation

To strengthen the offensive system, Utah should prioritize adding a secondary playmaker who can complement the primary ball handler.

Rather than relying on a single creator, introducing a player capable of initiating offense and distributing the ball would help diversify playmaking responsibilities across the team. This would reduce the current dependency on primary ball handlers and create a more balanced offensive structure.

Target Profile:

- Guard or wing
- High assist rate
- Efficient scorer
- Strong off-ball movement
- Ability to create opportunities for teammates

Expected Impact

Adding a secondary playmaker would significantly improve the overall structure of Utah's offense.

With more distributed playmaking, the team would benefit from improved ball movement and increased assist production, leading to higher-quality scoring opportunities. A more balanced system would also reduce offensive predictability, making it more difficult for opposing defenses to anticipate and disrupt plays.

In addition, expanding playmaking responsibilities across multiple players would enhance the team's adaptability in high-pressure situations, allowing for more flexible offensive adjustments.

Conclusion

This analysis highlights an important distinction between performance and structure.

While the Utah Jazz demonstrate strong scoring efficiency and overall offensive production, the underlying system reveals a reliance on concentrated playmaking rather than distributed creation.

This structural imbalance limits flexibility and can reduce effectiveness in more competitive environments, where adaptability is critical.

Ultimately, Utah does not need more scoring — it needs a more distributed system of creation.

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